

Questioner: To start, I'd like to know how you'd like us to refer to your partner.

Respondent: Uh... I don't know. [PARTNER] is her name, so we can continue to call her [PARTNER], I haven't asked her...

Questioner: Very well, that works for me! How long have you been together?

Respondent: It's been[1-5] years and a bit.

Questioner: [1-5] years and a bit, okay. So, I'd like you to tell me about your story, your meeting, the context...

Respondent: So, we met... The context was the preparation for [Month Day], so a militant context, organizing a demonstration and workshops for [Month Day]. And then, when we liked each other, we did activities together. One evening, we went out with a group of friends to a bar, a sort of concert, and then one thing led to another, and we kissed. And then, that's it. And I don't know if I should elaborate.

Questioner: Yes, please do.

Respondent: Okay. And when we met, [PARTNER] was more in the "no exclusive relationship" mode. I was more on that side too. And then, actually, we met just before the lockdown. And so, yes, it was quite special, and we kind of locked down together. And actually, it happened quite naturally. The non-exclusive side was abandoned. We ended up saying that exclusivity suited us well. We still discuss whether exclusivity is okay or not. Today, we've slightly opened our relationship. But yeah, it was a pretty unique context to start a relationship.

Questioner: Yes, it could have precipitated or at least accelerated things by being confined together.

Respondent: Yes, that's right.

Questioner: And so, that was [1-5] years ago. When you mention [Month], it was [Month] [1-5] years ago, right?

Respondent: Yes.

Questioner: If you had to compare the quality of your current relationship with that of your friends, what would you say?

Respondent: Compare? I find it hard to compare relationships because, actually, it's always easier to say, "yes, my relationship is better than others" because we're in love and things are going well, and so on. In any case, from my side, I would find it difficult to compare, but if I had to, I'd say that I'm already happy to be in a lesbian relationship, let's say, and not in a heterosexual one. That's the most important thing. It removes a burden from the heterosexual constraints that can exist in couples: the mental load and the emotional load, all that. These are

things that, for me, don't exist in the relationship. Well, there are things, but it's not at the level of heterosexual couples, and that's really the only point where I think there's really something to compare.

Questioner: Would you say that this mental load is different, or really more significant for heterosexual couples?

Respondent: It's much stronger for "cis-" women, much more significant in heterosexual couples than in LGBT couples. Actually, I see it with my friends and sisters who are in relationships with men, the mental load is mostly on the women's shoulders rather than the men's. Then, I can't compare too much either because I don't live with my partner. So this aspect of the mental load is not on the same basis of comparison.

Questioner: In terms of household chores and so on, you mean? The sharing within the household.

Respondent: Since we live separately, when we're at each other's places, we automatically share the tasks too. It's not because I'm at [PARTNER]'s place that [PARTNER] will do the dishes or vacuum. We share this balance. I don't know how it would be if we lived together. In any case, it balances well, whereas in heterosexual couples, well, I take the example of my sisters because I mostly interact with them, or even my friends, the laundry, the dishes, thinking about putting away clothes, and [partner]. It's mostly them who think about it more than their guys.

Questioner: Now, if you had to compare your current relationship with your previous relationships?

Respondent: My previous relationships? In my previous relationships, I was with guys (laughs). So, if I had to compare, there is already much more communication; it's much more horizontal. There are no hetero scripts that can come into play, even despite ourselves. At the time, I thought I was in great relationships, but in hindsight, there were lots of little dominance issues, imbalances. A guy who doesn't communicate, a guy who only thinks about his pleasure, a guy who doesn't care... well, it's radically different. In the relationship I have today, there's care, communication, shared pleasure. It's radically different and much better today.

Questioner: May I ask how many partners you've had?

Respondent: How many partners? In long relationships with guys that really counted, let's say... [1-5]. The rest were short-term relationships.

Questioner: Okay. So, [PARTNER] is your first same-sex relationship?

Respondent: It wasn't my first relationship; there was a short one before. But it's my first long and stable relationship.

Questioner: I'd like you to talk about what you consider a high-quality relationship.

Respondent: For me, a high-quality relationship is, first and foremost, communication. Communicating about what we want, what suits us, what doesn't suit us, and that it comes from both sides. It shouldn't be just one person communicating their feelings and the other going "okay, fine." It's really total horizontal communication. A quality relationship is also knowing when to take time for oneself and not just diving into the relationship and being together 24/7 without taking time for oneself or doing activities just for oneself. It's super important to balance couple time and personal time. Sharing? Having different interests but being happy for the other. Intimacy too. For me, intimacy isn't just about sexual relationships. It's about being comfortable together, physical closeness but not necessarily sexual. It's all about being cozy together. For me, these are the qualities in a relationship.

Questioner: So, to rephrase a bit, it would be a respectful, generous relationship with sharing, and independent if I may say so? Respecting the other's intimacy.

Respondent: Yes.

Questioner: Anything else?

Respondent: Uh, no.

Questioner: How can we know if we're in such a generous and independent relationship?

Respondent: When we feel good, when we don't have doubts, when there's no conflict, and beyond conflicts, when we feel good in the relationship and don't question it, when it flows naturally, when we're comfortable.

Questioner: When you're not constantly questioning yourself, torturing yourself with doubts.

Respondent: Yes, that's it, not questioning yourself and feeling accepted for who you are. And if you do something, the other person is happy for you. That's the foundation.

Questioner: Can you give an example from your relationship with [PARTNER]?

Respondent: I'd say that in the [1-5 years] we've been together, the relationship has been good after [1-5 years] with a small setback at [1-5] years. But for the past year, it's really been like that. We haven't had a major dispute in a year. Small conflicts, yes, but that's normal in daily life. No major conflicts where we thought we were on different wavelengths. We communicate better when we're not on the same wavelength. If one of us has doubts, we talk about it more easily. We've learned each other's communication styles. We understand reactions aren't personal. It's more comfortable now because of the effort to build something together. We've worked individually on what could disrupt our relationship, reaching a harmonious understanding and communication.

Questioner: When was your relationship at its lowest quality?

Respondent: After the lockdown. It was a special bubble during lockdown, but reality hit hard afterward. I had many insecurities, attachment anxiety, fear of abandonment. It was the worst time because I projected my insecurities onto [PARTNER]. [PARTNER] had her issues too. It was the hardest time in our relationship, the early stages. If we're still together today, [PARTNER] would say it's because I changed a bit. I felt our relationship had potential and was determined to make it work. At one point, [PARTNER] wanted to break up, and I was devastated. But I persisted because I sensed the potential.

Questioner: The lockdown could create a bubble that bursts explosively for many.

Respondent: Yes, definitely.

Questioner: Conversely, can you describe a low-quality relationship?

Respondent: A low-quality relationship is when there's an imbalance in the couple's dynamics. For example, one person takes on the emotional burden, ensuring the relationship is okay, planning quality time, and checking in on the other. It's one-sided. Also, a relationship with any abuse, whether physical or emotional, is low-quality.

Questioner: You emphasize the importance of equality.

Respondent: Yes, it's crucial. After experiencing unbalanced relationships, reaching equality feels right. You realize past relationships weren't as good as they seemed.

Questioner: You realize balanced relationships exist, and you don't have to endure imbalance.

Respondent: Exactly.

Questioner: What are the most important aspects of a romantic relationship for you?

Respondent: Intimacy and communication are equally important. But I'd put intimacy first because it includes communication. They go hand in hand. They're the most important.

Questioner: Can you elaborate on what you mean by intimacy?

Respondent: Intimacy isn't just about sex. It includes being comfortable with each other, accepting each other completely, being physically close without necessarily being sexual. It's about little gestures like a kiss on the neck while washing dishes or holding hands while watching a movie. It's being physically and emotionally close and communicating deeply about our lives and feelings.

Questioner: It's a mix of physical comfort and deep communication, right?

Respondent: Yes, and ensuring consent in physical closeness. Always making sure the other person is comfortable with physical contact.

Questioner: Feeling comfortable on all levels sums it up?

Respondent: Yes.

Questioner: Based on your experiences, what does love mean to you?

Respondent: Love is accepting the person for who they are, beyond any constructed idea of them. It's about unconditional acceptance and welcoming them into your heart regardless of changes.

Questioner: Does this apply to friendship love as well?

Respondent: Yes, accepting friends for who they are, even if they change. It's about unconditional acceptance, though extreme changes in values might challenge that.

Questioner: Is it unconditional love?

Respondent: Mostly, but extreme changes in values might challenge it. Even with friendship breakups, a residue of love remains.

Questioner: How important is love in a relationship?

Respondent: Very important. It signifies a deep connection beyond superficial interactions. It creates a profound bond.

Questioner: How do you know your partner loves you?

Respondent: Through mutual understanding of love languages. We both make efforts to meet each other's needs, communicate openly, and show love through actions.

Questioner: Is it challenging to have different love languages?

Respondent: It was initially hard, but over time, we learned to understand and adapt to each other's love languages. It became balanced and reciprocal.

Questioner: Can you describe a recent positive interaction with [PARTNER]?

Respondent: We had a great conversation about potentially moving to [City]. It was a lovely projection of our future together, despite some differences. Also, I enjoy cooking for [PARTNER] while she's busy with her studies, which strengthens our bond.

Questioner: Is the projection itself satisfying, even if it doesn't materialize?

Respondent: Yes, because it shows our relationship's growth. Seeing [PARTNER] envision a future with me is wonderful, considering our past challenges.

Questioner: Can you describe a recent negative interaction?

Respondent: The biggest was [1-5] years ago when [PARTNER] wanted to break up. It was a tough period, but we worked through it and rebuilt our communication and balance. Daily negatives are minor, like differing priorities, but we handle them with mutual understanding.

Questioner: Do small negative interactions still occur?

Respondent: Yes, like when our priorities don't align. But we communicate and adjust, knowing we'll discuss things later.

Questioner: What challenges do you face in your relationship?

Respondent: Giving [PARTNER] space, respecting different timelines, and managing different visions, like living together. Balancing these differences is key.

Questioner: How often do you have small disputes?

Respondent: About once a month. We resolve them by communicating and making mutual efforts to understand each other.

Questioner: Besides communication, how do you maintain your relationship?

Respondent: We see each other regularly, share rituals like watching shows together, and make time for quality moments. I'd like more "dates" outside home, but it's challenging with [PARTNER]'s busy schedule.

Questioner: Do you know what could make you leave your partner?

Respondent: It would take a lot. If [PARTNER] wanted a polyamorous relationship, I couldn't handle that. It's about maintaining mutual understanding and boundaries.

Respondent: But really, there isn't anything else. There's nothing [PARTNER] could do that would make me say, "Okay, no, stop." Because even if [PARTNER] cheated on me, I'd be like, "Okay, why did you do that? It wasn't part of the agreement," and we'd talk about it.

Questioner: In summary, for you, the relationship may not be exclusive. But love, yes.

Respondent: Love and intimacy cannot be shared. But it goes both ways. It's not just... because often in non-exclusive relationships, it's like, "I want a non-exclusive relationship. But it would bother me if my partner went to see someone else." I can't share my intimacy with anyone other than [PARTNER], and therefore, I don't want [PARTNER] to share her intimacy with anyone other than me...

Questioner: Would you say this relationship is good for you?

Respondent: Yes, yes, without hesitation. Yes, because over the [1-5 years], I've learned a lot. From [PARTNER], from our relationship, I'm doing much better than I used to. In fact, it's a relationship that allows me to both connect with someone, have someone in my daily life who

cares about me, who wants to be with me, and at the same time, it's a relationship that allows me to have my independence, my space, my activities. And it's true that it's... it's super pleasant, it's really wonderful.

Questioner: Your daily functioning is, if I may say, regulated thanks to your relationship. Both personally and with her, you feel good on all levels.

Respondent: Yes.

Questioner: Would you say that [PARTNER] helps you achieve your goals as well, in terms of personal development?

Respondent: Well, she encourages me, she supports me no matter what I do. It's really wonderful, actually.

Questioner: Do you have concrete examples?

Respondent: Yes, whenever I have a [sport] match, I always get a message before the match like, "Go for it, I'm thinking of you," and a message afterward, "So, how did it go?" Or when I have an intense day of classes, there's always a message like, "So how did it go?" When I'm apprehensive about something, there's always support, a little word from [PARTNER] whenever I have an anxiety. Yes, there you go.

Questioner: I'd like to know if you think you're the same person as before your current relationship. In other words, has your relationship changed you?

Respondent: No, definitely not. I'm not the same person I was [1-5 years] ago because... I've learned a lot, just about love languages, about why I had my insecurities, and how to address them? Also deconstructing things that might have been ingrained in me, regarding, let's say, the emotional burden, the sharing of the emotional burden. What does it mean to be in a couple? Is it... the relationship escalator? Is that it or not? Because I still had [20-25] years of heterosexuality, so there were things that got ingrained in my brain that I've been able to deconstruct with my relationship. And it has brought me a lot. Because it's also my first real non-hetero relationship. And just transitioning from hetero to lesbian, well if I had to use the right word it would be pansexual. It changes a lot in my self-perception, in what I project outwardly, in how others perceive me, in what I want to do, in my work, daily, it has changed... A lot of things have changed. Yes, I've changed a lot.

Questioner: And do you think [PARTNER] has changed too since the beginning of your relationship?

Respondent: I think so. It's something we've talked about and yes. [PARTNER] has changed as a person too, in how [PARTNER] identifies... Thinking about love languages, communication, expectations, mine and hers... Actually, we often reflect on our love, [PARTNER] makes me laugh because I like talking about our love. I like having conversations about the health of our relationship and how we feel. And when we talk about our love regularly, we say to each other,

Respondent: "Wow, it's crazy, all the progress we've made, how we've evolved together." Yes, I think [PARTNER] has changed too.

Questioner: Would you say she's changed as much as you? In the same way?

Respondent: I'd like to say as much, because I don't know how [PARTNER] perceives it—whether I've changed more, or [PARTNER] has changed more, I don't know. I want to say it's the same because we've really supported each other through it all.

Questioner: So it was together, hand in hand.

Respondent: Yes, that's it. Yes, I'm a bit of a romantic and I like love, I think.

Questioner: Regarding the security in your relationship, do you feel safe in this relationship? Meaning, do you feel free to talk about your experiences, your thoughts without fear of judgment? Receiving comfort, attention...

Respondent: Yes, definitely. I feel safe. And as I said, in the beginning, I would have said no, at the beginning of our relationship, I didn't feel safe at all. Today, I feel extremely safe because if ever... We talk about everything. We met in a moment of feminist activism, and today, I've withdrawn a lot from on-the-ground activism, [PARTNER] is still involved in it, and we have differences in our views on activism and feminism. And yet... I forgot the beginning of the question, I don't remember why I was saying this (laughs).

Questioner: We were talking about your feeling of safety in the relationship.

Respondent: Yes, that's it. I feel safe because I can express my opinion, which is different from hers, without thinking, "Well, we don't share the same views anymore, so [PARTNER] is going to leave me," or that it will jeopardize our relationship. In fact, on the contrary, the fact that we have different opinions strengthens us because we accept that the other person has changed since we met. And it's cool. And yes, I feel... We talk about everything, and even though it scared me at the beginning to have a non-monogamous, well non-exclusive relationship, actually, today, I'm much calmer because I feel safe in my relationship. And we've discussed it.

Questioner: Now, I'd like us to address another dimension that is also very important in couple relationships, which is sexuality. It's a dimension that can be more or less important, obviously, depending on the people. What about you?

Respondent: Sexuality is important, but at the same time, it's not important in the sense that... For me, it's nice, it's good, it's cool. But at the same time, it's not something I need to feel good in my relationship. However, it's true that... for some time, I've felt a bit frustrated with our sex life because [PARTNER] is much more reserved. There are many factors that influence [PARTNER]'s sexuality that aren't necessarily compatible with mine. And it's true that sometimes I'm a bit nostalgic for the early days when it's the beginning, you make love all the time. And now, we almost don't make love anymore. But still, I value intimacy much more than sexuality, so it's okay.

Questioner: By the way, currently, if I may ask, what is the frequency of your sexual relations?

Respondent: Well, I haven't counted, but I'd say it's about once every two or three months.

Questioner: And does this include all forms of sexual activity?

Respondent: Yes, yes, yes.

Questioner: Can you elaborate on your satisfaction with your sex life? About the frustration you mentioned earlier?

Respondent: Yes. That's also part of the deconstruction work I've done. For me, before, I thought a couple should have an active sex life, like they show on TV. You see couples making love and they must do it once a week; otherwise, something's wrong. And at one point, I thought, "We don't make love anymore; something's wrong, our relationship isn't working." But talking with [PARTNER], I've realized I'm satisfied with this lack of sexual activity. I also know that this change in rhythm is temporary, and it's okay if we make love once every three months. Maybe in a year, we'll do it once a week, I don't know. It's okay. I've understood that a sex life isn't linear. There can be ups and downs, times when you do it every day for a week and then not for [6-10] months. I'm quite satisfied because I don't have a huge sexual desire either. And when I do, well, masturbation is always... there. But it's okay for me.

Questioner: I understand. (Screen sharing). Now, let's base everything on this small scale, ranging from 1 meaning "Not at all true," to 9 "Absolutely true." If I asked, "Generally, [PARTNER] really listens to me," what would your answer be?

Respondent: Hmm... 7.

Questioner: 7. Can you tell me why?

Respondent: Because sometimes I feel like I'm not really being heard on certain things. And it's okay, perfect listening doesn't exist, except with a therapist.

Questioner: Can you give concrete examples of moments when this happened?

Respondent: Moments when I felt it was a 7... When I had questions about activism, not understanding certain actions or things, or... I've left the collective now, but we were part of the same collective. I mentioned things about the collective's methods, and [PARTNER] was like, "Yeah, yeah." But I knew I wasn't really being listened to. But it's okay.

Questioner: And why 7, not 6 or 8?

Respondent: Because for the rest of the time, when I express stress or anxiety, or just worries... most of the time, [PARTNER] listens to me. I can't give you specific examples, just a feeling.

Questioner: Okay. Now, if I asked, on a scale of 1 to 9, how [PARTNER] generally listens to your needs.

Respondent: I think I'd say... 6.

Questioner: So between "moderately true" and "very true."

Respondent: Yeah.

Questioner: Can you explain why? Develop it?

Respondent: Because we have very different timelines, and it depends on the moment. For example, right now, I know that with [PARTNER]'s internship, thesis, and everything, a lot of things demand her attention. I know that her ability to listen to my needs isn't at its maximum right now. And it's okay; it's normal. It's also something that has caused friction in our relationship. I've felt that [PARTNER] wasn't necessarily listening to my needs, while I was listening to hers. It's something we discuss regularly. But at this moment, I know that with [PARTNER] having a lot of other concerns, stress... it's normal that [PARTNER] isn't as attentive to my needs.

Questioner: You downplay it, understanding that she's very busy, and you don't take it personally.

Respondent: Yes, yes, yes.

Questioner: And why 6, not 5 or 7?

Respondent: Because it's not moderately true, not very true, it's in between (laughs).

Questioner: In general, how satisfied are you with your relationship? On this scale from "completely dissatisfied" to "completely satisfied."

Respondent: I'd say "completely satisfied." Yeah, because when something's wrong, we talk about it. When something's right, we talk about it. At this moment, I'm completely satisfied with our relationship. For me, there's nothing that isn't working. Again, romantic relationships aren't linear either. There are ups and downs. And right now, it's going really well. So I'm totally satisfied with my relationship.

Questioner: Okay, more precisely, if we take this more detailed scale, wait (screen sharing).

Respondent: It's hard to give a 10/10. I'd say 9; it leaves room for improvement. But it's hard to give a 10, so no.

Questioner: Okay, I'll stop sharing my screen. We're about to conclude. I'll briefly summarize what we've discussed over the past hour. So, you've been with [PARTNER] for [1-5 years] and some change. You met during the preparation for a militant day, [Month Day], [1-5 years] ago.

You did several activities together. That's right? One thing led to another, building your relationship.

Questioner: You quarantined together, which may have accelerated things, bringing you closer. At the same time, the end of the quarantine was a bit difficult, especially for you, I'd say. When the bubble burst.

Respondent: Yes.

Questioner: At the beginning, it was complicated to establish an exclusive relationship because it wasn't [PARTNER]'s thing, but it was more yours. You initially had a mostly exclusive relationship, and now you're more open about it. You'd say your relationship is more qualitative compared to your friends' because it's not cis-hetero mainly, to summarize! (Laughs).

Respondent: (Laughs).

Questioner: It doesn't have the same mental load seen in society today, in heterosexual couples. You've had t[1-5] relationships you consider important. The others were more short-term, less impactful.

Respondent: Yes, yes, yes, yes. I consider "important relationships" those that last a long time. A [1-5]-month relationship, for example, isn't... a significant, impactful relationship... That's why.

Questioner: Okay, I understand. What's very important to you in a qualitative relationship is communication, equality, being independent while maintaining intimate moments together, and being generous and respectful. A low-quality relationship is the opposite—imbalance, lack of equality, one person dominating the other.

Respondent: Yes.

Questioner: Your concept of love involves accepting the other person despite their flaws, almost unconditionally, within certain value limits. It's about feeling comfortable with the person, sharing intimate moments, touching, discussing everything from silly to deep topics. Challenges in your relationship might involve the timing of discussions, but you resolve this by making an effort towards each other?

Respondent: Yes, exactly.

Questioner: What's important for maintaining your relationship is your little rituals and also having dates and different activities to enrich daily life.

Respondent: Yes.

Questioner: You've changed a lot since the beginning of the relationship. You've learned a lot, and [PARTNER] encourages you and is quite attentive. Is that a brief summary?

Respondent: Yes.

Questioner: Great! Do you have anything else to add? Maybe something important that comes to mind.

Respondent: It may seem very idealistic, but it's just that I've come a long way. This is the best relationship I've had. It's the relationship where I've flourished the most. I can't see how it could be more perfect.

Questioner: Okay.

Respondent: I don't see how I could have a better relationship than the one I have with [PARTNER]. That's why it might seem a bit idealistic. But I'm really happy in this relationship, and I wish everyone could experience this.

Questioner: I have a few demographic questions left. Can you tell me your age?

Respondent: [26-30] years.

Questioner: [26-30] years old. Do you have any children?

Respondent: No.

Questioner: Who lives in your household?

Respondent: Uh, my cat.

Questioner: (laughs). Yes, you live alone, as you mentioned earlier.

Respondent: Yes.

Questioner: What is your household income?

Respondent: Per month?

Questioner: Yeah. You can quantify it roughly, either low, medium, or high...

Respondent: [range]. Well, [range], let's say.

Questioner: Thank you. Before we finish, you saw on the form that there were two data-sharing options. You chose one. Are you still okay with it, or has anything changed after the interview and discovering the questions I asked you?

Respondent: No, no, it's okay.

Questioner: Alright, thank you. I'll ask you one more thing. Do you think you could recommend two people close to you who could nominate other couples that meet certain criteria and whom I could interview? Essentially, their role would be just like R.'s, not being interviewed themselves

but suggesting potential participants. Ideally, they'd suggest couples you don't know well, maintaining diversity and anonymity in our network.

Respondent: Okay, I have someone in mind. And I should give you their contact details, right?

Questioner: I'll send you an email today or tomorrow, asking for their contact details. You can contact them, explain the study context, and see if they're okay with it.

Respondent: Okay.

Questioner: I'll send an email either today or tomorrow. You can check with them and then send me their details. Thank you very much.

Respondent: Yes, thank you. It was very interesting. If the study results come out, I'd love to know what they say.

Questioner: There's a note at the end of the form with Miguel's email, who manages a lot of the study. You can contact him for any updates.

Respondent: Alright, thank you.

Questioner: No problem, thank you very much. It was indeed very interesting.

Respondent: Thank you, take care. Good luck.

Questioner: Thanks, have a good day.

Respondent: Goodbye.